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Fascist uses of conspiracy theories: alienation, anxiety, and false concreteness in the critical political theory of Franz Neumann

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ABSTRACT

Recent decades have seen a surge in the use of conspiracy theories by populist and autocratic political figures. This has sat alongside a renewed interest in using insights from Frankfurt School thinkers to open critical perspectives on fascist uses of conspiracy theories. This paper builds on resurgent interest in the work of Franz Neumann, and directs attention to the political manipulation of alienation and anxiety. Building on Neumann's insistence that a falsely concrete theory of history is in operation wherever conspiracy theories resonate politically, this paper argues for the neglected centrality of conspiracy thinking in nearly all instances of fascist politics. Conspiracy theories are a structural feature of fascism – a hypothesis that invites empirical testing to see if it might better fit the overall pattern. Neumann's political critical theory also returns our attention to the possibility of an antifascist critical theory with the political at the centre of its concerns, opening lines of inquiry that complement Adorno's insights into domination of the administered world and the culture industry.

KEYWORDS

Conspiracy theories; Franz Neumann; alienation; anxiety; fascism; Frankfurt school

Introduction

Over the past three or so decades we can note four complexly related phenomena. Firstly, the apparent resurgence of conspiracy theories in political life across the world (Evans 2020). Secondly, formerly marginal conspiracy theories seem to have gained prominence, especially over the past fifteen or so years (Berkowitz 2003; Jamin 2018). Thirdly, from the mid-2010s, many would-be politicians have gained traction, popularity and political office through the expedient use of conspiracy theories, which were a notable feature of populist, ethno-nationalist, autocratic, fascist and totalitarian politics this decade, around the world (Ali 2020; Barkun 2017; Bergmann 2018; Fuchs 2018; Krämer 2018; Ricard and Medeiros 2020; Zuckerman and Gessen 2019). Finally, in the past five or so years, there has been a renewed scholarly and public interest in certain insights of critical theory for helping us think about 'all of the above' (Ross 2016; Gordon 2019; Scheuerman 2019; Jay 2020). The purpose of this paper is the latter: to recover what may be of greatest value from the Frankfurt School of the 1930s for our theoretical understanding of the uses

of conspiracy theories for authoritarian ends, then and now. I do so by building on resurgent scholarly interest in German political theorist Franz Neumann's work this century (Honneth 2003; Heins 2006, 2007; Kettler and Wheatland 2019; Paxton 2004; Scheuerman 2018, 2019). I give closest attention to the nonrational factor in human freedom, the relationship between alienation and false concreteness, and the manipulative use of anxiety in the conspiracy theories of fascist politics.

As leading member of the Frankfurt School, Herbert Marcuse, notes in his preface to Neumann's posthumous essay collection,

'The Institute [for Social Research at Goethe University Frankfurt, the de-facto home of the Frankfurt School] had set itself the task of elaborating a theoretical conception which was capable of comprehending the economic, political, and cultural institutions of modern society as a specific historical structure from which the prospective trends of development could be derived. This undertaking was based on certain notions common to all members of the staff, notably that a theory of history was the prerequisite for an adequate understanding of social phenomena, and that such a theory would provide the standards for an objective critique of given social institutions which would measure their function and their aims against the historical potentialities of human freedom' (in Neumann 1957; viii).

In this introduction, I use Marcuse's quote heuristically, in two ways. Firstly, it functions as a counterfactual to help ascertain the extent to which the German postwar generation of critical theorists carried out Marcuse's voicing of their shared task, as I review and try to build on some of the insightful claims in recent scholarly work on other members of the Frankfurt School such as Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno, alongside Neumann. Secondly, I use it to guide the development of a basic analytic tool (see Figure 1) extrapolated from Neumann's work to observe and theorize the salient

	Psychological Alienation	Social Alienation	Political Alienation	emergence of Caesar
historical threshold; structuring effect	emergence of civilisation; division of labour, alienation from man & labour	modern industrial capitalism; hierarchical division of labour, competitive society	complex society, composed of plurality of groups; the political	when the masses tend to become politically articulate, and can and must be persuaded
psychological effects	alienation of ego from instinct; happiness is impossible; splitting, projecting, Othering	fear of degradation & dependence; susceptibility to persecutory anxiety	apathy, disaffection, cynicism, disavowal, denialism, rejection	identification; group belief in conspiracy; hatred of Them as cause of woe and named enemy
social effects	civilised society, conformity with norms & obedience to law, civility & manners, arts & 'kultur'	competitive society; docility; self-directed harm & other-directed animus, including persecutory blaming	no value consensus; ascent & descent of groups; society as competition, thus 0 sum, winners &/or losers, conflict	existence of significant groups invested in a conspiracy shared to build group identity; manipulated anxiety, danger to minorities
political effects	inner conflict & its effect on social and political involvement & atmosphere; can lead to social & political alienation – if thresholds are met	groups resist degradation through mass movements: struggles for justice & enfranchisement, recognition and articulation of alienation as injustice	low voter turnout; legitimization deficits, polarisation; paralysis of state (if Caesaristic)	naming of & mobilisation against enemy; activation of identification & regression into submission & possible extirpation through killing
dialectical irony	creates conditions for what 'we' now prize highly (civility, architecture, music fine art, literacy, literature)	creates conditions for which political justice becomes urgent struggle & creates legitimacy for them as struggles for social justice	the engine of political creativity, positive social change & justice in modern industrial society	mobilised group destroys the civilisation of the society & polity they claim to be fighting to save; pogroms, camps, war, barbarism
influence on Caesarism	ineradicable connection between alienation & mass susceptibility to Caesarism & conspiracy thinking	appeal: as groups feel threatened, persecutory anxiety is induced; if unmet needs are manifest, conspiracy thinking appeals to 'threatened' groups	inflection point: Caesar can take anxieties, scorn the rules of the game, utilise indecision, manipulate identification, mobilise base	empirical emergence of any given Caesar; the successful existence of one creates demonstration effect influencing the emergence of others – Caesarism as model?
caveat or limitation	only relevant or active with social & political alienation, & presence of politically articulate masses and Caesar	hallmark of a competitive industrial capitalist society; relevant or active as a factor to the extent that there are real unmet needs inducing anxieties	unmet needs & anxieties must exist; social anxiety must be lived & felt; a Caesar still needs to appear, and to persuade	only possible if psychological, social, & political alienation combines with real anxieties & unmet needs – & there is a Caesar who can persuade groups; true?
missing; undeveloped Neumann's account	altruism, paleo-archaeology & sociology; defence mechanisms; ontological insecurity (Laing) & schizoid; freedom as existential homelessness freedom (Fromm)	sociology of networks & groups; media, culture, cultural memory; race, gender, and intersectional analysis; provincialisation of Neumann's North Atlantic Eurocentrism (India, China?)	role of media & platforms; political economy of media ownership; societal success & learning; antecedents (Austria-Hungary)	genealogy of specific Caesaristic practices & conceptual genealogy of Caesarism; cultural contingency (e.g. Prussian militarism, American neoliberalism, Russian autocracy)

Figure 1. Neumann's mechanics of Caesarism, alienation, anxiety and false concreteness in 'Anxiety and Politics'.

social, political, and psychological relations between conspiracies and fascism, then and now. This paper also builds from the following core claims from Neumann's work.

The first is that Neumann contends that 'political theory is concerned with the truth', and that '[t]he truth of political theory is political freedom'. Freedom has *three* elements: juridical, cognitive, and volitional. This paper examines one hinge between the cognitive and the volitional, where thought can undermine action. Neumann then says why this is *necessarily* a critical theory:

'Since no political system can realize political freedom fully, political theory must by necessity be critical. It cannot justify and legitimize a concrete political system; it must be critical of it. A conformist political theory is no theory' (Neumann 1957, 162).

The second claim, which is particularly crucial in the paper's later section on the conspiracy theory of history is that 'the historical process has a meaning' (Neumann 1950, 164). If conspiracy theories show us an important instance of where political freedom, as truth, is impeded by the nonrational, then Neumann's claim about the meaningfulness of the historical process shows us why we cannot know in advance what those meanings are, and so must always look to what they may be. This beckons us toward Adorno's ideal of 'open thinking' (Cook 2018a) and invites a theoretical attitude of curiosity and openness to the 'now', in light of its unfinished pasts (Adorno 2006, 89; Neumann 1950, 164–7), for all that follows.

It is also important to establish in this introduction that Neumann contrasts a fundamental conflict between rationality and nonrationality in modern politics. On the one hand, the rule of law is *strictosensu* 'rational' (in the Weberian *zweckrational* sense): it produces calculability, limits interference, and, ideally, (re)produces the generality of law (Neumann 1957, 162–70). On the other hand, Neumann sees clearly that the 'rule of law' is also usually an ideological veil obscuring the 'rule of people' – power relations. He also notices the stubborn fact that 'power cannot be dissolved in law' (Neumann 1950, 166). Power, the 'rule of people over people', still operates; and power is also conducted by way of its nonrational cognitive elements, alongside the juridical and the volitional. The mutual indissolubility of law and power creates political conflict, which thus also always takes place, at certain moments, *in the realm of the nonrational*. This means that critical political theory must also deal with the role of the nonrational in the many political systems in which we live. Finally, Neumann gives primacy to the role of anxiety (above aggression, or destructiveness, or fantasy) (Neumann 1957, 180, 184) as the nonrational factor in modern societies that annihilates freedom above all, and tends to make us a slave of authoritarian and totalitarian leaders (Neumann 1957, 184). In sum, Franz Neumann offers a critical political theory that explores the historical meanings of where and how anxiety tends to destroy human freedom.

Why is such a theory important now? The full spectrum of 'new' right-wing extremism has to be seen as a political phenomenon whose objective bases are still alive in society (Adorno 2020, 8; Adorno 2006, 89–90; in line with Mann 2004; Paxton 2004). Adorno and Neumann offer different descriptive analyses of what those objective bases are, in ways that merit a renewed social theoretical discussion that this paper hopes to contribute to. However, the key point in the primacy of the political in right-wing extremism is to build on Adorno's 1967 insistence that fascism, *which is still with us*, is not 'purely psychologically motivated' (Adorno 2020, 7, 8). If we allow this

is the case, a critical theory enquiring after fascist uses of conspiracy theories should then retain focus on the political, and avoid the trap (Heins 2007) of giving explanatory primacy to a psychologizing explanation – *because* history has meaning (Neumann 1950, 164, 164–7). This becomes analytically delicate to the extent that one is explicating nonrational factors and giving power to the unconscious and the techniques by which it is manipulated, as Adorno’s most famous works on fascism do (Adorno 1982, 2000, 2001). And it becomes paradoxical, to the extent that *recht* and *raison* – the rational operation of power, and the reason of the truth of freedom – always also involve the nonrational, as Neumann assumes.

Ultimately, re-exploring Neumann’s critical political theory offers a complementary normative foundation for contemporary work in critical theory, building on recent work on Kirchheimer and Neumann (Buchstein 2020; Kettler and Wheatland 2019; Scheuerman 2018). This should be an antifascist theory, I contend (and see Cook 2018). All the thinkers associated with the Institute for Social Research in the Weimar years and 1930s – Walter Benjamin, Erich Fromm, Marcuse, Neumann and Otto Kirchheimer – expressed a staunch antifascist orientation in their work, regardless of their other substantive differences. Indeed, with the complicated exception of Horkheimer (Buchstein 2020), and while regarding the fractious status of antifascism in the group’s debates in exile in the late 30s (Kettler and Wheatland 2019), most Frankfurt School – associated thinkers contributed their own substantive critiques of fascism, despite the many contradictions and disagreements within the network (Buchstein 2020; Jeffries 2016; Rickert 1986). In other words, and in line with Deborah Cook’s reading of Adorno and Foucault (Cook 2018, 16), for the majority of the Institute’s thinkers, and in their most cited and influential works, a principled opposition to fascism was a crucial component of a critical theory worthy of the Institute’s name and task. What follows in this paper is an exploration of what a normatively antifascist political theory might recover from Neumann and that aims to build a little further – and more critically – in relation to well-established insights of Adorno, not just as intellectual history, but to better understand something that ‘lives on’ in *our* political present, and in us (Adorno 2006, 90; Deleuze and Guattari 2004, 31).

Critical theoretical insights for the age of the Cultural Marxism conspiracy theory: a review of key literature and recent scholarly work on autocracy, fascism, and the Frankfurt School

Why might the networks of contemporary social theorists comprising this journal’s readers think through the role of conspiracy theories in fascist thinking with insights from the first generation of the Frankfurt School? In answering this question I will first examine in some detail the contemporary societal and scholarly context in which it is asked.

In the 2010s, interest in the Cultural Marxism conspiracy once again began prominent (Braune 2019; Jamin 2018); this contributed to the twenty-first century revivification of interest in the Frankfurt School lineage of critical theory. The Cultural Marxism conspiracy was formulated by Paleo conservatives as a weapon in the prior context of US culture wars of the early 90s, beginning with campus debates about political correctness (Berman 1992; Weigel 2016). But from the early 2000s (Berkowitz 2003), and accelerating from

2009 via the Tea Party and the rise of Breitbart News (Breitbart 2011), its promiscuity and resonance increased dramatically, moving far from 90s US culture wars and campus identity politics to provide ideological justifications for far-right massacres in Norway and New Zealand (Bergmann 2018; Besley and Peters 2019). That is to say: the massacres in those two locations were, in complex senses, justified through the use of a conspiracy theory involving Adorno and Horkheimer. Interpolating Peter Gordon's interpretation of Adorno's re-reading of *The Authoritarian Personality* (Brown, Gordon, and Pensky 2018, 63–4), this implies a dialectical over spilling of the premises and implications of Adorno's own methods and results into the society being critiqued; Adorno and Horkheimer are now involved and implicated in the very barbarism their work analysed.

What are the key tenets the Cultural Marxism conspiracy theory? As it appears in the manifestos associated with both massacres, copy/pasted from Andrew Breitbart and William S Lind, the theory holds that Horkheimer, Adorno, Marcuse and the network of exiles later known as the Frankfurt School, secretly conspired to destroy the United States by effecting radical and corrosive cultural change in educational institutions. On Andrew Breitbart's own detailed telling (Breitbart, 2011; 105–159), Adorno and Horkheimer infiltrated the US while exiled in Malibu in the 1940s, on the imprimatur of György Lukács, carrying out a plan handed to them in a secret meeting in 1923 (Lind 2018). Their later disciples, leftist academics working in US liberal arts colleges, are – to this day – secretly conspiring to destroy the American way of life. In the 1960s, on Breitbart's telling, this plot permeated elite institutions and news media via the counterculture. Into the present, those sections of the alt right still reusing iterations of Breitbart's version of the conspiracy theory broadly contend we can observe its work wherever students have been turned onto intersectionality, sending them queer and woke – and destroying free speech through the imposition of a censorious political correctness (Breitbart 2011; Lind 2018). Alt right and culture-war reactionaries have contended it is these groups of Cultural Marxist academics who must be opposed and destroyed. In a strange way, all of this is a reaction to Adorno and Horkheimer, and proof of the power, or haunting, of the first generation of critical theory.

In one sense, the scholarly tactic of responding to this by using the Frankfurt School afresh is, perhaps, a desire for an apposite negation. For what could be more dialectical than the use of critical theory to negate the abuse of critical theory by fascists peddling conspiracy theories – about Adorno and Horkheimer in Malibu? In this section, I 'test' the idea that we could attempt this negation as a means of taking us from the recent interpretive return to Adorno to the under-utilised insights of Neumann on alienation, anxiety and false concreteness.

Carrying this dialectical aptness to the context of the polarization of the US in the 2010s first, what does it mean that Adorno and Horkheimer were cast as protagonists of a conspiracy theory that contributed to the election of Donald Trump, inspired the alt right, and was used as the ideological justification for the mass murder of unarmed people with no stake in, knowledge of, or connection to any of this? As Scheuerman notes, more than anything it's 'the ascent of Trump and that of others made from the same shoddy cloth (that) have brought renewed attention to Adorno's ideas, with The Guardian, The New York Times, The New Yorker, and other prominent publications highlighting their value as a source for interpreting authoritarian populism ...' (Scheuerman 2019, 452; Ross 2016; Jay 2020). Much of what follows in this literature review

section tends to refer most to Adorno, because he is the Frankfurt School thinker that the alt right and its public and scholarly critics reached back for most consistently to explain the contemporary context. An implicit purpose, then, is to critically review this resurgent literature to see whether, in fact, Adorno is the best placed thinker to help us apprehend fascist uses of conspiracy theories, given the context of 2010s autocracy, and internet conspiracy cults (Badham 2021).

In helping us make sense of the rise of the alt right in the later 2010s, the excellent critical examinations of autocracy by Gessen (2017), and of social media by Seymour (2019), draw inspiration from Fromm and Adorno (respectively) and apply their insights to understanding the co-creative tendencies of autocracy and social media in the later 2010s, from Breitbart to Trump. Volker Hein pinpoints what may be of greatest value in Adorno's thinking that can be applied to this conjuncture: how power operates in the twenty-first century (Heins 2006). This is an interesting claim, especially if we take on Deborah Cook's claim that 'Adorno insists on tracing all phenomena, including social conflicts, back to the economy and exchange relations' (Cook, 2018: 92 of 285), and notice too that Cook wrote a whole book whose purpose was to retrofit Foucault's analytics of power back into Adorno's essays and aphorisms – to show power's operation at work in the damaged lives of hapless individuals subsisting in the harsh blue light (Didi-Huberman 2002) of the reified world.

Heins' interpretation of Adorno complements Cook's by squaring this circle of exchange relations and power relations, for he writes that 'the intriguing discovery of Adorno's writings on the culture industry is that power may not only be working by surveilling and punishing people but also by turning them into onlookers and connoisseurs with a remote control in their hands' (Heins 2006, 69). Heins' repossession of these insights also brings Adorno closer to Bernard Stiegler's use of Adorno and Horkheimer in his critique of 'computational madness' (Stiegler 2019, 3–7) and spiritual and symbolic misery (Stiegler 2011), factors also explored in the documentaries of Adam Curtis over the past fifteen years (Curtis 2011, 2016, 2021). Here are some fresh contemporary sites for Adorno's critical theory, then: bullshit jobs (Graeber 2018); scraped-out institutions (Zuboff 2019); platform users scrolling feverishly toward anticlimax, with no belief or future (Stiegler 2019); the annulment of resonance¹ through control (Rosa 2020), the production of resentment that works *against* social transformation, bolstering the very social conditions that create grievance and frustration (Vogl 2023). Adorno can be read anew in light of these contemporary social theories as a theorist of 'twitchy, agitated interpassivity' and 'reflexive impotence' (Fisher 2009, 24, 21) for a society of Netflix with no chill. This does not yet tell us directly about conspiracy theories and fascism in the age of Trump, but it does lead us to a critical understanding of the precise societal and cultural contexts in which internet conspiracy cults proliferated so quickly, and speaks to why they may resonate now, and for whom (Connolly 2005).

A second way of re-reading Adorno here is as the mirror of a time in which the culture industry 'does not make people really happy', leaving us 'strangely frustrated without knowing what else to desire or even how to articulate this frustration' (Heins 2006, 64; Stiegler 2011, 2019). At the same time, the desubjectified consumer, seduced by the lure of the streaming spectacle that scrolls us toward anhedonia again and again, is *also* one of many who are convinced of living in a world of conspiracies; that is, a world without accidents in which everything is connected and nothing is accidental

(Evans 2020, 1), but where ‘the sources of cultural power remain ultimately obscure’ (Heins 2006, 64). In other words, Adorno’s work still has much to say about the societal trends and cultural tendencies (Adorno 2019, 23–32) that have produced such widespread investment in conspiracy theories, as well as so much loneliness; a world in which ‘people make associations, and there’s no meaning’ (Knight 2021); it begins to tell us why even the comparatively advantaged and prosperous may be disaffected, angry, and hate-filled enough to enact mass murder – including, perhaps, in the name of the Cultural Marxism conspiracy theory, in order to defeat the ‘scourge’ generated by Adorno and Horkheimer, once and for all (Lind 2018).

Moreover, Adorno and Horkheimer’s work explores how *groups* work in such a reified society, leveraging and manipulating what remains of institutions and the public good, by engaging in rackets (see Heins 2007; Scheit 2018; Buchstein 2020; Pohrt 2013; Jay 2020; Fuchschuber 2019; Ruttner 2021). Racket theory was Adorno and Horkheimer’s attempt, in the late 30s, to provide a theory of how and why groups conspire. In thinking about the constitutive role of groups involved in conspiracies and rackets, Heins reminds us of what Adorno often referred to by way of terms like ‘swindles’, which we can see elsewhere through Adorno’s use of the term ‘spell’ (*Bann*), something which, having been broken, produces incredulity as to how we were ever ‘under’ it (Adorno 2006; Turner 2016). Adorno’s insistence that what takes place in society now – between unequal’s, in and between mutually opaque groupings, in relations of domination – is something between a conjuring and a con that happens behind people’s backs, using a repertoire of tricks that go over people’s heads as much as through them, is worth exploring anew here (Adorno 2006, 26; Cook 2018). For all these reasons, there may be merits in returning to these strands pulled from Adorno’s critical theory in ways that re-emphasize how the manipulative techniques of leaders ‘wind up’ (Seymour 2019) the irrational in groups, and this could be used to better illuminate the dank online darkness that Adam Curtis, Mark Fisher, Bernard Stiegler, and Joseph Vogl’s work brings us to.

However, on the political and the institutional, Adorno and Horkheimer and their most revisited works are curiously undeveloped, in a way that leaves much to be desired for apprehending the fascist uses of conspiracy theories. For Heins and Scheuerman, the charge is one of hypostatization: especially of the political. Buchstein goes further, arguing that ‘at no point in theory production did ‘the inner circle around Horkheimer ‘have an elaborated theory of the political or of political institutions at its disposal’ (Buchstein 2020, 82). In a sense, and as Buchstein and Scheit have noticed, racket theory stands in lieu of this, but Buchstein follows Wiggershaus in regarding racket theory as an ‘unfinished torso’ (Buchstein 2020, 98). The precise reasons for this are complicated, dating ‘back to the beginnings of the Frankfurt School’ (Buchstein 2020, 82), and are in evidence in the many debates in exile that have only been recovered in depth and full detail through recent scholarly work (Buchstein 2020; Kettler and Wheatland 2019).

Using Adorno’s postwar essays and lectures on the political and institutions (Adorno 2019), I now examine salient moments from these works to pinpoint what Adorno’s critical theory might tell us about the political in conspiracy theories and fascism, then and now. Adorno lays out some of his postwar thinking on the political in lecture five of *Philosophical Elements of a Theory of Society*, where he allocates it a dialectical value: it is (usually) *purely* ideology, yet it (occasionally) *really* is the sphere of seizing

power, 'where it is quite possible for the entire fundamental conditions of life, especially the economic ones, to be decided' (Adorno 2019, 39). Thus, for Adorno, 'politics is the manifestation of ideology that can take hold of the substructure and move it in a different direction' (Adorno 2019, 39). This would mean that fascist politics is the manifestation of its ideology, which adds tension to the space between where the psychological is manipulated, and where we can notice the substructure being moved in a different direction, as a result. What can we take from this that is of use for understanding fascist uses of conspiracy theories, in line with Marcuse's voicing of the Institute's task, and Adorno's insistence that fascism is primarily a political phenomenon?

For generous readers, claims of dialectical moves are evidence that Adorno knew what he was doing and was two steps ahead of the critics: this slightly '4D chess' interpretation is how Gordon reads what might otherwise be read as inconsistencies in Adorno's purposes and assessments of *The Authoritarian Character* (Brown, Gordon, and Pensky 2018, 63–4). What Adorno says in lecture five may have been as far as he wished to go (Cook 2018, 35 of 285), and in reading his other comments on the political in lecture eight (Adorno 2019, 66) as well as his influential psychologically oriented contributions to understanding fascism (Adorno 2000; Adorno 1982; Adorno 2020), we can surmise this as: a concession to a world in fragments; perhaps because of his summative description of society as a racket and of politics as 'struggles and confrontations ... increasingly reduced to struggles between the most powerful groups – one could almost say to pure clique battles' (Adorno 2019, 66); due to the movement of Adorno and Horkheimer's insights from racket theory into the theory of antisemitism in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (Scheit 2018, 1559), and; Adorno's attribution of causal, explanatory factors to *techniques* of manipulation grounded in depth psychology, laid out in the 30s (Adorno 2000), which he returned to consistently in the 50s (Adorno 1982, 2001) and 60s (Adorno 2020). For this reader, what Adorno says in lecture five on the political is too equivocal and ambiguous to be of robust use to a theory that maintains that fascism is a political phenomenon – as Adorno and the best scholarly accounts do (Adorno 2020, Mann, 2004, Paxton, 2004) – while the comments in lecture eight might lead us to the settled view that it was still a variant of racket theory by 1964. It may also be read as affirming Buchstein, Heins and Scheuerman. Inadvertently it also speaks to Cook's book-length co-attempt to complement Adorno and Foucault (Cook 2018). Counterfactually, why add Foucault's analytics of power, if Adorno already gave us a sufficient account of power's non-economic bases? As the sum of this suggests, the reason why Adorno's political theory seems inconsistent and vague is because it was not properly developed, did not fully exist.

In contrast, Adorno's postwar thinking on history and culture remains supple and open (Cook 2018; Gordon 2019); his work into the 1960s retains a commitment to a philosophy of history and a critique of society, and his postwar public lectures on fascism are surprising, open, and continue to reward close reading (Adorno 2006). We do not get as far as Horkheimer's ossified view of society as a set of collusive agreements between power groups pursuing particular interests, the point at which his 'theory itself assumes something of the character of conspiracy theories' (Heins 2007, 793). But as Scheuerman notes, Adorno's view of social totality still 'sometimes vanishes' (Scheuerman 2019, 454). This is hardly surprising when viewed in relation to Adorno's philosophical orientation; *Negative Dialectics* was a self-declared anti system, and Adorno

professed that the whole is a kind of vanishing point only expressible by delineating its tendencies and contradictions (Adorno 2019, 22). However, Scheuerman's claim is not that Adorno does not have a political theory, nor that his aphoristic style obviates the need for one. Rather, Scheuerman contends the theory is there in Adorno's work, but remains incipient and imputed, although it is recruited at certain points to do a considerable amount of work. Where it does surface, Scheuerman argues, it is a 'a latently functionalist social theory' (Scheuerman 2019, 454), one in which modern domination *actually* works, neatly and smoothly. On re-reading this with and against Adorno's 1964 lectures, this seems approximately correct, especially if we allow that he continued, to some degree, to lean on Horkheimer's insistence on the racket as the 'elementary form of domination' in contemporary society (Scheit 2018, 1551). To Cook, the theoretical consistency is more due to Adorno's strong insistence on the haplessness of the individual in a thoroughly reified society (Cook, 2020). However, to this reader at least, Adorno consistently expresses a cynical view of why ordinary people are manipulated by contemporary society, grounded in dismissals of their freedom (in Neumann's sense), *due* to their historically contingent domination by the nonrational factors of the administered world and culture industry. Manipulation is brought to bear on reified masses by manipulators, who to *some* extent know what they're doing – in the following ways.

Where fascism's receptive audience is concerned, Adorno contends we are dealing with 'the true children of today's standardized mass culture, largely robbed of autonomy and spontaneity' (Adorno 1982, 134). People are susceptible to manipulative techniques *because* of weak egos – so weak they are no longer even individuals with psychologies (Adorno 1982, 136). Rather, 'fascist collectivities' are formed by 'post psychological deindividualized social atoms' (Adorno 1982, 136): the agitator, due to their particular character type, can turn his unconscious outward: 'All he has to do in order to make the psychology of his audience click, is shrewdly to exploit his own psychology' (Adorno, 1982: 133). This is a tension in Adorno's work, because although he still insisted that fascism was primarily political as late as 1967 (Adorno 2020), and conceded that only an 'explicit theory of society ... transcending the range of psychology, can fully answer the question of why the applied group psychology under discussion was peculiar to fascism' (Adorno, 1982: 133–4), his consistent insistence on the pervasion of reification by exchange relations, and the way its psycho-social effects produce 'social atoms', negates *nearly* any positive political meaning to ordinary people's struggles and involvement in fascist politics. Adorno was not that curious about the possibility of an historical meaning of fascism beyond objective reification and subjective regression, which speaks to why his substantive critiques return again and again to regressions triggered by manipulative techniques, and focus on the techniques, before reflecting back on the political status of this. This brings us to a more critical theory of Adorno's critical theory.

Curiously, Adorno's own attitude to power (Neumann 1950, 164–7) deprives him of a view that can countenance the more political possibility that many ordinary German individuals freely – autonomously, spontaneously, *consciously* – also chose to be Nazis, because they wanted to (Theweleit, 1987) or because they benefited from Nazism (Aly 2008; Tooze 2006). One might even turn the psychoanalytic tables and suggest that dismissals of Germans who became Nazis as 'deindividualized social atoms' with 'weak egos' might actually function as a defence against seeing 'the horror that one hesitates to call it by name' (Adorno 2006, 89): Nazism, freely and consciously chosen for its material

benefits (see Aly 2008; Tooze 2006; Feuchtwanger 2022), or the conscious enactment of desire (Theweleit, 1987). At the very least, consistent recourse to the psycho-social effects of reification tended to deprive Adorno of curiosity about the live meanings of politics at certain historical moments in Germany's twentieth-century history, and perhaps even the open thinking he cherished so much (Cook 2018; Gordon 2019). Neumann – a point we'll return to – had parallel difficulties in facing antisemitism. Seeing Adorno's struggle with his own German identity, culture, history, loss and guilt also gives some insight into the complicated difficulties and discomforts Adorno expressed in his view of the German student movement of the 1960s (Richter and Adorno 2002), and shows his difficulty in really listening openly to Elias Canetti discussing his theory of crowds, which was very strenuously *not* grounded in Freudian group psychology (Canetti 1996; Canetti, 1990: 11–121).

What was fascism, then, and what might it be now – a *primarily* political phenomenon? In seeking answers, should we pursue Horkheimer's iteration of racket theory, dwell on antisemitism (an important weakness in Neumann, which I return to), or stay with Adorno's beautiful essays on psycho-technics (Adorno 2001) that work to the extent we live in a historical era in which the 'decline of the individual and his subsequent weakness' (Adorno 1982, 120) makes populations susceptible to bands of gangsterish leaders who can turn their unconscious 'out' as they employ psychological manipulation to dupe weak egos? If so, how then can we think politically about the 'Führerless' group identities involved in the attacks in Norway and New Zealand, how can we theorize the alt right in the American decade just past, how can we think about contemporary authoritarian populism and neo-fascist politics right across eastern and western Europe, north America, and Brazil? I now turn to the Frankfurt School thinker who, I argue, is better placed to add insights on current political uses of conspiracy theories in this context: Franz Neumann.

Social anxiety, modern politics, false concreteness: Neumann's political understanding of the uses of conspiracy theories for authoritarian ends

In this section I seek to demonstrate that the work of Franz Neumann better serves us in making sense of contemporary conspiracy theories than that of Adorno. I do this by firstly reconstructing the historical relationship that Neumann identifies between alienation and false concreteness in the conspiracy theories of fascist thinking. The short summary of Neumann I offer upon entry is this: different kinds of alienation combine to trigger anxiety in contingent ways. For Neumann, Caesarism² describes situations when agitators manipulate triggered anxiety for their own political purposes. This takes place through the creation of an enemy, who, having been made the personification of history, can then be mobilized against, and destroyed through organized killing. Where this mobilization transforms into a movement seeking to purify the *socius* through paramilitary violence (Mann 2004; Paxton 2004), we have reached the threshold of fascist political action proper. That is to say: fascism is the politics of extirpation. This also gives us a counterfactual that can speak back to 'fash', alt-right, autocratic and mafia-state tendencies in contemporary society (Fuchs 2018; Connolly 2017), because, from this Neumannian perspective, it is not yet *quite* fascism until the politics of extirpation is called for and enacted via mobilization. To prepare the reader for where the next sections

are heading, extirpation forms the horizon of fascist politics, based on mobilisation striggered by conspiracy theories, marshalling the nonrational aspect of freedom we know as anxiety.

To organize this chain of contentions more clearly than Neumann's speech presents them, I provide a diagram that retains Neumann's analytic distinctions and explicates the relations and inter-active conditions of the many elements in his argument. This is intended to help disclose the complication of emergent conditions where conspiracy theories tend to actually become politically dangerous at any given conjuncture. This should also help us understand where the manipulation of anxiety resonates, as well as showing structural patterns in fascist uses of conspiracy theories. To do justice to Neumann's intentions and legacy, I also hope it gives a fairer and more accurate and detailed assessment of his insights and contribution than some recent attempts (Hornet 2003; Fuchs 2017).

Let us give this more focus by returning to the task that Marcuse set for critical theory for just a moment. Recall that Marcuse contends 'a theory of history was the prerequisite for an adequate understanding of social phenomena' (in Neumann 1957: viii). Remembering Neumann's core contention that the historical process has meaning, in the context in which Marcuse's preface appeared this reads an attuned nod to the 'clue' Neumann repeatedly offers in 'Anxiety and Politics', where the centrality of history for understanding anxiety and politics is stated up front. As Neumann writes,

'The clue which will frequently permit us an early diagnosis of the regressive character of such a mass movement... is the view of history which the masses and the leaders employ. It may be called the conspiracy theory of history, a theory of history characterized by a false concreteness' (Neumann 1957, 279).

So then: Neumann is saying very directly that the conspiracy theory of history is key. This aligns clearly with Marcuse's delineation of the Institute's task. This also shows how closely Marcuse was reading his friend Neumann, who also counterposes his own theory of history to this, throughout 'Anxiety and Politics'; but what was this theory?

Returning to Scheuerman to assist us with this, we learn that by the 1950s, Neumann had moved beyond the Marxian functionalism of Pollock, 'along with the idea of contemporary society as a totality where the various pieces of the puzzle fit neatly together, despite its latently antagonistic core' (Scheuerman 2019, 457). Neumann's conviction broadly follows Karl Mannheim, insofar as he contends that modern society is fundamentally plural, and Carl Schmitt, insofar as he contends it is antagonistic (Neumann 2009, 11, 79, 444): but these antagonisms are not those of class struggle determined 'in the final instance' by the mode of production (Anderson 1976): unlike for Adorno, exchange relations do not have *a priori* primacy (Cook 2018). Economic and social relations and capitalist competition are still there, to be sure, as are commodification, alienation, and the commodity and labor market. However, the political retains some degree of relative autonomy and creative power throughout Neumann's work (Neumann 1957, 2009). Neumann's theory of history can be retroactively placed in a Schmittian 'spectrum of intensity' (Schmitt 1996, 26, 59) with the supple agonism of later Foucault (1982) at one end, Schmitt (1996) voicing the hard line, Mouffe in the middle (Mouffe 2013), and Mannheim and Schmitt (and Laski, Spengler, Weber and Sorel) as its deeper theoretical background.

We must add, however, Neumann's consistent, continual focus on *groups* in contemporary society, always described sociologically and in the plural: the political is less a relation, as it is for Schmitt, than relations. Moreover, in Neumann's political theory, antagonism is less *a* Schmitt an 'relation' where enmity perennially defines *the* political than it is a dialectical movement between groups engaged in processual relations of domination, constraint and coercion, and freedom and agency (Neumann 1957, 270). In Neumann's theory of history, then, the political functions as the font of ineradicable group conflicts *and* the engine of positive social change, the arena where live meanings are made. The meaning of history is political; politics makes meanings, sometimes producing freedom and truth, sometimes their nonrational annihilation. Sometimes it is just a power struggle between particular interests, but sometimes the struggle 'may indeed represent the idea of freedom, the idea crucial to political theory' (Neumann 1950, 179). It's worth noticing the contrast between this account and the terminus of Horkheimer's late 30s and early 40s thinking about groups in contemporary society as rackets (Heins 2007; Scheit 2018). For Neumann, there are rackets, and there was National Socialist gangsterism (Neumann 2009, 301, 305), but this is not all, and politics is not over. Society, including in Germany between 1933–1945, was never post-political (Heins 2006).

Neumann is thus not 'simply' many of the kinds of theorist he has been cast as. He is not a communitarian political philosopher tarrying with Freud (Honneth 2003); not a left Schmittian; nor was he a faithful inner-circle acolyte willing to toe Horkheimer's line and hew to its agreed orthodoxies (Kettler and Wheatland 2019; Rickert 1986). But he's also not just the product of Laski, Mannheim, and Neumann's doctoral milieu of the 1930s London School of Economics, because he was also a Social Democratic Party labour lawyer from Weimar Germany and an Institute for Social Research associate. Yet he was also really *not* any kind of orthodox Marxist: Hayes' imputation that '*Behemoth* abounds with unquestioned and doctrinaire Marxist clichés' (in Neumann 2009: xiii) rings false. *Behemoth*, like the posthumous essays, always has recourse to a 'multitiered analytic framework' (Scheuerman 2019, 458) in which the realms of the social and economic, as well as the legal and political, are related, distinct, agentic, live factors.

This marks a turning point in our ability to formulate a cogent theory based on Neumann's work. As Scheuerman contends, the move beyond functionalism back into a world of many live, inter-active factors is the key that truly 'opens the door ... to a more differentiated analysis than Adorno's of authoritarian psychological patterns and their relationship to political and social processes' (Scheuerman 2019, 457). The methodological entailment of this opened door is also clear. The relation 'between political and social forms of authoritarianism', Scheuerman insists, 'must ... be taken as a special [empirical] problem, and not as an automatic correlation' (Neumann in Scheuerman 2019, 457). Again: history has meaning, but we do not yet know what those meanings might be. The potential theoretical dividend of this attentiveness carries a 'tax' for the reader, for we can no longer be satisfied with the pessimism of postwar Horkheimer at his gloomiest, the negations of Adorno at his wittiest – for if we accept it, we must plough through and explicate every given example, as Neumann did with *Behemoth* (2009). What happens when a differentiated analysis taking political and social forms as empirical problems is brought to bear on alienation and false concreteness in the conspiracy theories of fascist thinking, using 'Anxiety and Politics'?

In the context of ‘Anxiety and Politics’, we have already noted that Neumann is applying his own pluralistic, agonistic theory of modern history to another whose meanings are antagonistic to it: the false concreteness of conspiracy thinking. The second point is that ‘Anxiety and Politics’ is highly summative: short and seemingly clear phrases imply much that could not have been explicated for that 1953 West Berlin audience, but are treated elsewhere in detail in Neumann’s published work, or that he was still working out before his untimely death in a car crash (Neumann 1957, 233–256). Thirdly, Neumann’s logic in the paper has lawyerly clarity, but his sociological style is contextual and heuristic. I describe it as a mechanics, for it seeks to guide the handling of distinctions while retaining enough analytic clarity to show that the political, the social and the political are related, distinct, and inter-active. But Neumann’s lecture also structures its claims in a highly systemic way; there is a tight and formal relation of whole and part where each of the assertions are predicated and selectively activated by their relation to the others. That there is a definite overall structure to the lecture means it must be attended to from start to finish, then grasped overall. Notably, Honneth’s (2003) reading fails to do this, missing the clue of history Neumann gives up front, and renders Nazism as an exception that cannot speak beyond its context (Honneth 2003, 253). But what’s most curious about Neumann’s formal, systemic way of proceeding is that, at times, he seems to be working backwards: ‘first’ conditions, such as social anxiety, tend to be presented toward the end, while key consequences are dealt with up front. In order to avoid an exhaustive line-by-line reading of the text, and to help this paper’s readers see some points that are a little buried, [Figure 1](#) re-presents this paper’s author’s interpretation of the many elements of Neumann’s thinking in ‘Anxiety and Politics’. The task for thinking them through in this section is to consider them – all at once – as inter-active conditions.

By looking closely at this tabulation of Neumann’s thinking, I reconstruct the following about psychological, social and political anxiety; Caesarism and the theory of history it uses; *and* the usefulness of all of this for understanding the fascist uses of conspiracy thinking in the political present. Readers may find it helpful to check this paper’s account against Honneth’s reading of ‘Anxiety and Politics’, as well as Adorno’s ‘Freudian Theory and the Patterns of Fascist Propaganda’ (Adorno 1982); I refer to both closely, although to keep the focus on Neumann’s contribution, in line with this paper’s contention, I include them where their details are most relevant for explaining what Neumann was pointing at – as in the following.

Psychological anxiety, first of all. As Heins writes, the move from alienation to psychological anxiety begins with our own experience of ourselves as alien: ‘before the individual starts believing in alien powers bent on plotting against the world, she or he feels herself or himself to be an alien. Becoming an alien, psychologically speaking, implies being unable to connect to others in a meaningful way. The social world becomes all smoke and mirrors’ (Heins 2007, 794–5). Identification remains the psychological mechanism that enters with political resonance here, for Neumann *and* for Adorno: alienated masses become ‘supporters’; they outsource their good sense to the leader who they then become invested in, aligned with and obedient to. As discussed in the literature review, Adorno leans more heavily on the leader’s repertoire of rhetorical tactics in effectuating this, leading to his memorable description of Hitler as ‘a composite of King Kong and the suburban barber’ (Adorno 1982, 127). Adorno’s ‘Freudian Theory and the Pattern of

Fascist Propaganda' also attributes ensuing political behaviour to (prior) unconscious causes (weak ego) that have arisen because of objective social conditions (reification) – because manipulation can only create a powerfully regressive identification where a group of human subjects have already internalized authoritarian relations in a society in which that individual subsists 'in a thoroughly reified society, in which there are virtually no direct relationships between men, and in which each person has been reduced to a social atom, to a mere function of collectivity' (Adorno, 1982: 136). Although Neumann shares and uses Adorno's insight about regressive identification as the place or moment where 'what takes place in people's heads' *includes* political manipulation that goes 'over them' (Adorno 2006, 27), he does not give political valence to imputations of a 'blind, heteronomous and potentially destructive' (Adorno 2006, 28) introjection, such as Adorno posits. Neumann's account is, contrastingly, as follows.

Neumann ascribes none of the *necessary* or causal political or social valence to psychological alienation, nor to its *knowing* manipulation through the creation of regressive identifications, although he draws directly on Adorno's Freudian work, and prefers it to Fromm's account (Neumann 1957: n299). For Neumann, psychological alienation remains an ineradicable aspect of our modern 'civilised' lives, but it only becomes amenable to manipulable uses under certain modern social and political conditions. The key point for understanding the fascist uses of conspiracy theories, from this, is that this means it's these self same societal conditions we ought to focus on and understand first: because they provide the material for manipulation. Concrete anxieties – grounded in unmet needs and emerging from ordinary lived experience – are what's decisive for Neumann. Formative deprivations are what matter, rather than the introjection of an authoritarian father and the primal horde (Adorno, 1982), which can later successfully be triggered by a manipulator's techniques, to the extent they're 'post psychological deindividualized social atoms' (Adorno, 1982: 136). For Neumann, only such existentially grounded alienation – which presumes both someone who is still an 'individual' with a 'psychology' – is capable of triggering anxieties or effectuating manipulation, not just primordial identification unlocked through the oratorical casting of the spell (Adorno 2000), nor botched processes of attachment and separation, then social endangerment (Honneth 2003, 253). Adorno leads us away from the political; Honneth leads us away from what we should learn from Nazi society in Neumann's political theory; Neumann points us back to the recurring social conditions in which groups become susceptible to manipulation. Society, and how people construe their struggles and strivings *now* provides the triggers, not formative parental experience, or weak ego.

Social anxiety is crucial to the structure of Neumann's political analysis – much more than the space given to it in the lecture. It is social anxiety, in contrast to psychological anxiety, that delineates the historical age in which we live – by becoming possible under the hierarchical division of labour that Neumann contends characterizes modern industrial capitalism. In turn, this division of labour is what gives rise to the competitive individualistic society Neumann describes (Neumann 1957, 289), where '[a]lienated individuals experience the social world as unchangeable and themselves as playthings of uncontrollable powers' (Heins 2007, 795). Herein, some individuals try to accommodate themselves to the apparatus, some identify with competition and heroic competitors, some turn their angst on themselves. However, the groups at the heart of this paper's concerns work up their anxiety together, then discharge it in a persecutory direction.

This account of the role of social anxiety in a competitive society appends Neumann's account of the political by historicizing it further: antagonistic relations between groups possessing their own antithetical values, interests and concerns are a conspicuous feature of *modern* societies (and see Mannheim, 1968). So, to contrast once more, where Adorno looks to personality styles, manipulative leaders and what might break the spell, and Honneth looks to the endangerment of inter subjectivity and the need for recognition, Neumann looks to social alienation, especially that experienced by vulnerable social groups. If we follow Neumann, then the problem we need to countenance is not so much depth-psychological as it is depth-societal. The problem is how an alienating society has created material deprivation and profound loneliness – it's not bad parenting (Honneth), or the reanimation of the primal father (Adorno, 1982: 124). This can also open onto interesting and fresh links with the strong empirical findings on the profound societal effects of loneliness and anxiety (Murthy 2020; Putnam 2020; Turkle 2017), and the strong emerging correlations between social media use and catastrophic mental health effects, since 2012 or so (Haidt 2023; Vogl 2023).

The social *and* the political are related, insofar as social anxiety is always also politically creative. As I've contended, noticing this articulation is crucial for Neumann's account of history and social change, and again, in contrast to Adorno, it is more capable of surprising us than the terminal recurrence of reification everywhere. For social anxiety generates mass movements where groups develop identities and contentions and fight the social degradation *they* construe as integral to their group identity – which they then contend by engaging critically with or becoming disaffected from institutions, and via political opposition, or apathy.

The hinge between the social and the political is also the place from where groups project norms and goals for change and justice to aspire to (Neumann 1957, 287, 290): it is a potential site for the rational expression of political freedom, as well as a conduit for the nonrational. This also means social anxiety is dialectical, denoting as it does the movement of a society's fundamental antagonisms: both in the arena of the political, in alienation from it, and in the realm of exchange relations. Hierarchy generates the dream of equality; domination generates the call for emancipation. This is the crux of how the political still exists and is creative in Neumann's theory, and it speaks to enactment of his conception of the dialectic of freedom moving *through* the societal problem of anxiety and *especially in groups*, not just 'individuals' and impaired autonomy (Honneth 2003, 253–4).

This means social anxiety is the central enabling condition with the greatest political weight. It is social factors that Neumann says matter most for our politics and its dangers, all their unevenness and contingency – more than the discontents of civilization (still always there). To the extent that there are real unmet needs and worries – as Neumann contends there must be – conspiracy thinking becomes commensurately appealing, most of all to groups who feel existentially vulnerable (and see Zuckerman and Gessen 2019). As groups come to feel their way of life is threatened via the precarity of job, income, status or prestige, and as individuals and groups fear competitive struggle, or foresee their loved ones and interests will be hurt, dishonoured or destroyed by competition, persecutory anxiety is induced, and then can be worked up in group-based discourse. Caesarism, or populism, or autocracy, or fascism, then rises or dissipates based on the degree to which actual anxieties are *then* manipulated for authoritarian ends.

For all of these reasons, a social theoretical understanding of the inter-activity of the conditions in which conspiracy thinking appeals could do well to direct close, sustained attention toward the sources and effects of social anxiety, how they circulate and resonate, and how they're grounded in the deeply felt anxieties and unmet needs of people struggling to live in a competitive society. Analytically, in relation to the structure of the argument and all the factors Neumann puts in play, it's the closest 'Anxiety and Politics' comes to calling causality. If we notice and accept this, it might direct scholarly attention on this topic away from the authoritarian personality, which still tends to lead to sweeping condemnation of cultural forms, such as where Gordon explains Trumpism as 'not a social pathology but another instance of the general pathology that is American political culture' (Brown, Gordon, and Pensky 2018, 68). Rather, contemporary social theory might look at or past Trumpism and be genuinely curious about global post-industrial issues such as loneliness and involution (Liu 2021). This can also be used to build on Dardot and Laval's (2014) development of neoliberal society and neoliberal subjectivity through their re-reading of Foucault, or investigate where Stiegler takes Adorno and Horkheimer to a critique of digital society and its destruction of a sense of spirit, belief in the future and production of misery (Stiegler 2019). In other words, rather than returning to Adorno and rendering contemporary politics as the ideological trap and spectacle of manipulator and dupe, magician and spellbound, or following Gordon's use of Adorno in rendering the entirety of 2010s US political culture as pathology, Neumann's model helps us to better consider which groups are struggling most to live now, to investigate why, and develop concepts that can begin to say what those struggles might be creating, or lead to. This brings us from social to political anxiety.

In Neumann's structure of factors and conditions, political anxiety sits between the social and the psychological as a kind of 'conditioning condition' (Juarrero 1999, 129). On the one hand, political anxiety is proximately causal, as in its absence there could be no groups possessing antithetical values treating politics as a zero-sum game for scarce resources and articulating this in concrete struggles, or falling into apathy, quietism or nihilistic despair. In a public and consequential sense, this would mean that, absent political anxiety, there would be no polarization, no legitimization deficits, no potentially corrosive public dissensus that could paralyse the polity, should a Caesar then arise (I return to this) (Neumann, 1959: 270). As with social alienation, political alienation recursively influences emergent psychological factors, for without political alienation there would be little apathy, disaffection, cynicism and disavowal that could resonate with anxious groups and mobilize, or paralyse, individuals. In turn, these subjective, psychological, modern experiences of political anxiety recur socially, feeding group identifications or perhaps building a culture of denialism or resentment – potentially fuelling popular demands to reject the whole system and burn it all down, but perhaps in ways that contribute to its entrenchment (Vogl 2023). Theoretical attention might then be directed to the complexly causal hinge between the social and the political, and its psycho-social manifestations. Given the recursive logic in play, theoretical models may find it optimal to go by way of complexity and systems theory, as Connolly (2005) and Vogl (2023) attempt. Here, Neumann's mechanics can assist by specifying with greater precision the conditions under which specific – and ideologically incongruous – alliances and assemblies, and their resentment, can form.

However, Neumann was no incipient systems theorist, nor was he any kind of supple agonist. The insistence on antagonism that he shares with his antagonist, Schmitt, brings his analysis or political anxiety out of the recursive causality of social anxiety, with all its feedbacks and overflows, asraised. For Neumann, antagonism between groups is a feature of modern society that is dialectical insofar as its tension and intensity generates political change *and* destructive conflict. In *eliminable* conflict, as we can no more get rid of it than we can do away with the undercurrent of discontents generated by the emergence of civilization (the view he shares with later Freud, Marcuse and Adorno). Neumann's hard antagonism shows us to the limit of his insights in 'Anxiety and Politics', for it spells out an engine of historical change and emergent meanings, without saying what directions it might take – nor can it tell us what, if anything, might lead our societies out of the set of conditions in which all of this tends to recur.

In his work and professional commitments, Neumann's political theory shunts the possibility for change into education (Kettler and Wheatland 2019), the uses of institutions and the generality of law as imperfect bulwarks, and the threefold complexity of freedom (Neumann 1957, 160–201) lived in law, thought, and action. Neumann expressed these commitments in his teaching, writing, Office of Strategic Services work, and role in denazification and the rebuilding of the West German education system. But as for combatting fascist uses of conspiracy theories, this section's close read of 'Anxiety and Politics' has argued that most of the implied agency – for us as social theorists now – seems to reside in attending to the structural causes and lived effects of social anxiety, because its presence is contingent, unevenly distributed, based in passionately felt unmet needs, and are what's generative of persecutory anxieties. As I read Neumann: we cannot get rid of the political, but we needn't accept Schmitt's decisionism, for we can make a modern society less antagonistic by reducing hierarchy and competition, just as we can – perhaps – cultivate publics less credulous toward false concreteness, through better education. It is this set of proposals, which remain as modest as they are elusive, that contain some potential to dampen the appeal of the conspiracy theory of history, which I now directly address.

The conspiracy theory of history: from false concreteness to the fascist politics of extirpation in the act of killing

The conspiracy theory of history is characterized by false concreteness. This amounts to the assertion that there are no accidents in history, everything happens for a reason and is connected, and at the heart of things there is a group deserving our enmity who have always been secretly controlling things, destroying society to advance 'their' nefarious ends. This is apiece with recent scholarly summaries of conspiracy thinking that Neumann's work anticipated (Chambers 2022; Evans 2020). What's specific to Neumann's contribution is the mechanics of his argument, and this leads us from Caesarism, in general, to fascism, more particularly – as follows.

False concreteness works by personifying the secret controllers as an enemy, a 'Them', then placing this in a narrative, turning it into a story. For Neumann, groups look for deliverance from their woes, then, if a Caesar emerges (again, we must return to this), they get traction by identifying the *causal* They – the definite enemy group who have wrongfully caused this whole bad world. Neumann is emphatic that the use of false

concreteness generates *an* enemy as a personification of the historical process: for only hatred of an enemy can integrate a ‘people’ in such conditions (Neumann 1957, 287). The They come to ‘appear as genuine enemies whom one must extirpate’ (Neumann 1957, 279), not mere scapegoats. We reach beyond Caesarism to the threshold of fascism, in Neumann’s model, when supporters enact a politics of extirpation by mobilizing violently against the declared enemy. Bringing in insights from recent scholarship (Mann 2004; Paxton 2004), articulating fascism in practice then depends on cultures of militarism, groups’ ability to mobilize paramilitary violence, and actual acts of killing – with the participation of or sympathy from the military.

Neumann leans as hard on false concreteness as he does on social anxiety. Neumann writes that ‘wherever ... caesaristic ... leader-identifications occur in politics, masses and leader have this view of history’ (Neumann 1957, 259). Although Caesarism is itself a nonpartisan and contingent emergence (Stalin is cited as an example on the left, Cola di Rienzo a historical populist example), *wherever* it arises, Caesarism *always* relies on a conspiracy theory of history – and this can become fascism when it evolves into a politics of extirpation. This strong claim is at the core of what Neumann is attempting, so a fairer critique of Neumann than Honneth’s (2003) would rest in ascertaining the extent to which this is in fact the case, use it to generate counterfactuals, or consider how this might work in the absence of a leader. The further key point that immediately follows is that this is also a testable hypothesis as regards fascism: it generates a key element for a critical theory of fascism that can be brought into dialogue with the other scholarly accounts we have, as this paper is seeking to introduce here. It can be said with some confidence that conspiracy theories did play – differing, specific – roles in Italian fascism (Valbousquet 2018), Francoism (Bannister 2014), Nazism (Evans 2020), Stalinism (Neumann, 1957), and in the contemporary fascism of the alt right (Gruzd and Mai 2020; Scott and Overly 2020). Neumann’s theoretical claim about the centrality of false concreteness opens the way to new empirical understandings, and invites us to revisit what we may have missed in our studies and theories of fascism with fresh curiosity.

Conspiracy theories of history: are they causes, effects, or symptoms? Richard Evans’ recent historical scholarship on the Hitler conspiracies insists that conspiracies are expressions – rather than causes – of divisions and polarisations (Evans 2020). In the inter-activity of alienations explicated in ‘Anxiety and Politics’, that is definitely true. Returning to what Neumann insists about social anxiety, we should look closely at the real struggles and unmet needs in people’s lives to understand where this really comes from. But Neumann’s lesson for understanding the fascist uses of these anxieties, more particularly, *in* the contingent points where they tend to emerge throughout modern history, should by now be clearer. Rather than a co-presence that should keep surprising us, fascism and conspiracies could be empirically tested as being causally related, because the former relies on the latter. Conspiracy theories are a structural feature of fascism: this may be Neumann’s most neglected and important political insight on this topic. That the structural role of conspiracy thinking has been largely missed in recent, influential accounts of fascism (Mann 2004), including Paxton’s, which is influenced by Neumann (Paxton 2004), makes this a fascinating direction for re-examination.

In pinpointing the mechanics of false concreteness, Neumann contends that it's the kernel of truth that makes any personification of history dangerous. History has meaning – thus identification works as much by reinterpreting events in history that are *somewhat* true, and so creating new meanings, as it relies on the irrational belief in those events as causes manipulated through a set of techniques deployed as the agitator turns his unconscious outward (Adorno, 1982; 133). Contra Adorno, this is why giving explanatory primacy to 'the casting of the spell' and explicating techniques, while genuinely useful, will always prevent us from giving relative equality to the possibility that actual historical contingencies and consciously known and embraced cultural worldviews – freedom – is at least as much in play. Yet even any psychological identification is also always thoroughly political and historically contingent, for as Neumann writes elsewhere, Caesarism only works once the masses become politically articulate (Neumann 1957, 237). False concreteness involves conscious political speech, freely (volitionally) chosen (Neumann 1957, 184–6), although it perforce draws upon nonrational factors in triggering anxiety.

This means that nonrational factors *have to be* considered in and alongside social contexts where groups retain solidarity and do boundary work by sharing and building narratives: consciously known, intentionally organized, reflexively understood. This means we might direct more precise attention to the political contexts in which people's views are accorded or denied value and have contested or negated agency, where exploitable resentment is generated (Vogl 2023). This is an interesting opening for the most undeveloped aspects of Neumann's thinking, alongside gender and antisemitism: the role of news media, and, to return to Adorno's strength, how Neumann's account might help us think more clearly about the spectacles, seductions and rackets of today's culture industry online. For where Heins might contend that Adorno shows us how Fox News seduces its viewers, Adorno might say they're under a spell, or Horkheimer might dismiss them as 'ants in an ant heap' (Heins 2007, 796), Neumann's insistence on a degree of knowing and articulation, as well as ambivalence, doubt and curiosity, might begin to say better than Adorno does (Adorno, 1982: 136–7) why the agitator still needs to persuade its audience to agree with what they already know, want to believe and identify with, and also keep telling them a story that they are already libidinally invested in.

Neumann draws out the full political valence of alienation and anxiety through a three-step process of intensification that can lead to fascism, the politics of extirpation: through manipulation (1), identification (2), false concreteness (3). In Neumann's theoretical construction, in the historical examples he gives, and in the case of fascism, National Socialism, Trumpism and Putin's mafia state, to name but a few, there is almost always a subsequent call to action. Thus there seems to be a fourth step in the process, which Neumann describes but does not directly add to his step logic. It should be added; I add it. Neumann names this 'fourth step' by regaling his audience with examples of murder plots from Thucydides and Dostoyevsky, a sharpness that could not have been lost on his West Berlin 1954 audience:

'All that business of titles and sentimentalism is a very good cement, but there is something better; persuade four members of the circle to do for a fifth on the pretence that he is a traitor, and you'll tie them all together with the blood they've shed as though it were a

knot. They'll be your slaves, they won't dare to rebel or call you to account. Ha ha ha!' (Neumann 1957, 292).

Structurally, mobilization, volitional freedom, *action* (Neumann 1957, 184–6) becomes significant in the 'fourth' step. The identified are induced to offer their contribution to the movement, and do so by mobilising, involvement and actions that include plotting, doing in – conspiring. In such contexts, a belief in conspiracies ends by way of conspiring – *concrete* conspiring, Schmitt might insist – wherein groups then go out and kill the enemy. As the group 'gives back' to the movement by conspiring to 'do for the fifth', the political bond produced is the 'fascia', the blood knot of those who have killed the enemy together.

On Neumann's telling, this creates a circuit between crime, morality, evil and purification: the leader orders crimes, but they're read back as moral acts. This is one moment where it *does* become Freudian for Neumann, as repressed guilt intensifies anxiety (and see Adorno 2006, 89), and this tends to be overcome by further surrender to the leader, who orders new killings. This spiral destroys the dialectic of freedom and domination by creating the tightening bond of blood-bonded guilty slaves, a group who wills its own domination, enacted through the extirpation of the enemy. It is this mobilization into deadly paramilitary action that creates actual fascists, groups of people enthusiastically willing to totally purify society through paramilitary violence (Mann 2004; Paxton 2004). The sharing of the conspiracist view strengthens identification with the leader, and if the identification is strong enough, if social and political alienation resonate enough, if the false concreteness in its personification of the Enemy compels, the enemy is named: trapping the group in a tangling, knotting cycle of purifying killing, morality, guilt, obedience, purifying killing. In the absence of opposing forces, the political bond of fascism is finally and fully produced when the group is caught in the fate of a political movement of escalating deadly violence whose binding act is when the group actually goes out and kills the enemy.

Conclusion: from the fascist politics of extirpation to the possibility of an antifascist critical political theory

This paper has sought to open a number of paths for theoretical enquiry by showing how the relationships between alienation and false concreteness in fascist uses of conspiracy can – still – spiral into a politics of extirpation. Neumann shows us that fascist uses of conspiracy theories are contingent, intelligible and recur in a patterned way whose structure can be given schematically and tested against empirical cases. This enables us to see continuities in the recurrence of conspiracy thinking across modernity, re-figuring Nazism as but one conspicuous example of a tendency of our political life in common, not just an exception that can be wished away, or that doesn't speak beyond itself (Honneth 2003, 253).

Understanding these aspects of modern political history should also lead us to doubt that conspiracy thinking is something new, recent, about postwar America, or just caused by the culturally dominant uses of the internet and social media (Chambers 2022; Evans 2020). This opens the way to a more critical theory of conspiracy theory, one that casts scepticism on accounts that talk about conspiracies as excrescences of the information

society (Dean 2000), or postmodern ways of dealing with complexity and uncertainty by thinking ‘the impossible totality of the contemporary world system’ (Jameson 1991, 38). In line with Neumann, conspiracy theories may be better understood as durable problems of modern capitalist societies riven by competition, alienation and antagonism, where groups who feel vulnerable tell themselves powerful stories about total wrongful causes and, in certain situations, overcome their indecision through the extirpation of the enemy. Accounts privileging the role of online platforms and communities have very important things to tell us about the many distinctions between then and now (Ali 2020; Gruzd and Mai 2020; Seymour 2019; Badham 2021), but the fact that Neumann had much to say that’s relevant before and beyond this suggests the past few American decades and ‘the internet’ have been over-represented in Anglophone literatures on conspiracy theories and fascism (Chambers 2022), are worth doubting a little more, and look different in the broader context presented here. Moreover, if conspiracy theories are to some measurable degree a structural feature of fascism, as this paper has argued, then their presence and pervasion should be taken seriously – following Neumann, as serious signs of societal anxieties and the inability of institutions to contain it, wherever there is resonant agitation.

In this paper I’ve intimated that Neumann’s insights might offer one complementary point for a critical political theory with an antifascist purpose, in line with Marcuse’s voicing of the Institute’s task. What might this mean, finally? To begin with, conspiracy theories can destroy the possibility of inter-communitarian, truth-based political intersubjectivity through the application of false concreteness: first to the group’s own abstract and one-sided view of causality and history, by way of the elaborate story they build about the enemy responsible, and then to the concrete destruction of target populations, institutions and democratic society. An antifascist critical political theory beckons us to consider our own philosophy of history, as Neumann and Adorno did in their work. And yet, did these thinkers of the Frankfurt School live up to Marcuse’s voicing of their common task? In concluding, one must consider the following two significant blind spots, one in Adorno, that supports Neumann’s approach; the other in Neumann, that leads back to Adorno’s.

Much of the 2010s discourse on American autocracy looked back to Weimar (Ross 2016; Scheuerman 2019); very little looked *just* a little further back, further east. Counterfactually, we would do well to reconsider the formative influence of fin-de-siècle Vienna more closely, especially its protean, populist, autocratic, proto-Nazi politics, for this was Hitler’s Vienna (Hamann, 1996), where he learned how to be himself, and taught himself how to ‘do’ politics, manipulation, and agitation. This period of disintegration (Broch 1932) was also the final two decades of the golden age of Freud’s bourgeois individual and his psychology (Adorno, 1982: 136). If one looks to the 1880s rise of Schönerer, or the 1900s prominence of Lueger, one finds psychological individuals and the bourgeois family still intact, as well as high levels of social and political alienation, and the resonant manipulation of anxiety by agitators – such as the pair just mentioned. It is a milieu that lends itself to Neumann’s political critical theory, and also casts doubt on Adorno’s critical theory of reification, for two reasons. Firstly, as Jameson notes, ‘[t]he lasting achievement of the Frankfurt School ... lies ... in its vivid demonstration of the reification of the subject under late capitalism’. However, this ‘demonstration depends for its force on the hypothesis of some previous historical stage in which the subject is

still relatively whole and autonomous' (Jameson 1977, 392). If we look to fin-de-siècle Vienna as a time at the end of the previous historical stage, but still within it (by Adorno's own reckoning), one might expect to find stronger ego, less atomization, and (thus) less susceptibility to manipulation by agitators, including those using antisemitic conspiracy theories. Schönerer was a creature of the fringe, but Lueger was mayor, with a thumping majority, and enjoyed widespread support from many of the populist and Christian newspapers and their supporters. Hitler learned a huge amount from Schönerer and from Lueger by paying close attention to how they worked and by *consciously* absorbing what they said. Here is a clear case of individuals learning from individuals, in ways that lead to the worst fascism known thus far. Secondly, the fact that German phone society *since* Nazism has been more durably resistant to its new right-wing extremism speaks to a counterfactual, for if we follow Adorno's theoretical metanarrative, that would imply a less reified society comprised of individuals with more conscious freedom than in the 'reified past'. Applying open thinking here: perhaps Nazism does not correlate with reification (so, maybe, reification, however present in some places fascism emerged, does not *explain* fascism); perhaps this too is false concreteness, a one-sided narrative held by a group – of critical theorists. Now to Neumann's blind spot, antisemitism.

Neumann soft pedals German antisemitism, to the point of absurdity. As Scheit contends, Neumann's work evinces an 'inability to place antisemitism center-stage as the determinant delusion in this total process' (Scheit 2018, 1560). Neumann 'ignored it as the unifying factor in this process of disintegration' (1565), and in this sense, for Scheit at least, he 'fell short of the potential of Critical Theory' (Scheit 2018, 1559), and the Institute's task. One may again look to Austria-Hungary and the rabid antisemitism of Schönerer and his pan-Germanists, or Lueger's antisemitic populism, to see one foundational place of demonstrable and formative antisemitism. In fin-de-siècle Vienna, one should also notice that Mahler, Wagner's foremost interpreter in this milieu, left for New York because of the unbearable antisemitism, that Wagner was antisemitic (and that this was hugely influential, including on Hitler), and that Kaiser Wilhelm II was vociferously antisemitic, in ways that influenced Schönerer and Lueger. One could also look to Germany in the years immediately after the war, as Theweleit did, especially at the fantasy contents of demobilized German soldiers, and notice their conscious, direct obsession with Jewish women's bodies and murder (Theweleit 1987). In the same years, we could also look at how theories of Jewish conspiracy took hold with the 'stab in the back' (Evans 2020), with Wall Street immediately cast as the 'global Jew' (Tooze, 2008), from 1918. For these reasons, Neumann's assertion that 'the German situation can be understood only when one becomes aware of the fact that in Germany before 1933 spontaneous antisemitism was extremely weak', before re-quoting himself in *Behemoth*, '[t]he writer's personal conviction, paradoxical as it may seem, is that the German people are the least anti-Semitic of all' (Neumann 1957, 286), strikes this reader as a strange and counterintuitive position to maintain. At this point, we might return to *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, where, Scheit suggests, we can see where the rackets ended up and also consider if antisemitism can be seen as the 'determinant delusion in this total process ... the actual reason why the process and the organized community became indistinguishable' (Scheit 2018, 1560). One might also look again at the free and conscious assertion of Nazism and antisemitism in the

historical work of Götz Aly (2008) and Adam Tooze (2006), and consider those who were Nazis because they *wanted to be* (Theweleit 1987). We must accept the enigma that Neumann freely chose his counterintuitive interpretation, ‘paradoxical as it may seem’. Following his own theory of political freedom, this means it too includes its nonrational elements.

And what of contemporary fascism, finally? If we interpret fascism proper as a politics of extirpation, then its threshold was never quite reached in the first Trump era. There was ‘attempted fascism’; there were fascists. And there are fascists. Looking at the ‘aspirational fascism’ (Connolly 2017) of Trumpism in light of Qanon and the Capitol Attack, we are left with the question of the Caesaristic leader, and ‘his’ absence, or question-mark figuration, as Q. Looking at the attacks in Norway and New Zealand, pseudo-anonymity, as well as the absence of any notable, single, prominent leader, is a significant distinction of these contemporary online groups and internet conspiracy cults. In Norway and New Zealand, group identities worked out an Enemy online, and a lone individual then worked through their own false concreteness toward a desire for extirpation, which they enacted. This casts doubt on the need for a Caesaristic leader, *in these* precise contexts. In contrast, looking at the early 2020s aggression of Putin’s mafia state, we still see the stern face of a leader, alongside the reduction of the movement’s figuration to a single letter, Z (Gessen 2021). With the propaganda justifying the invasion of Ukraine in 2022, we saw the over determination of false concreteness by antisemitism, National Socialism, *and* Cultural Marxist tropes, as Ukrainians were re-cast as Russians ‘under attack’ from queer Nazis led by a Jew, who must be destroyed because of the existential threat They posed to Russian Orthodox anti-Nazi masculinity. Reading ‘Anxiety and Politics’ in the era of Q and Z indicates some limits of Neumann’s model, but its mechanics, by way of social anxiety, can say with some precision how the non-rational was implicated in these political moments, especially how this was directed in persecutory ways that annihilate freedom. This leads us to an anxiety we rightly have about our fascism, not as something over there, something Other, something past, but as an immediate and present possibility that can arise in the historical meanings unfolding in the anxieties of our politics, now.

Notes

1. I note the very different valence that Connolly and Rosa give to resonance, without pursuing that here.
2. Though the ambit of this paper precludes my pursuit of this further, the decline of the political use of this term is theoretically notable, appearing as it does in major works of Spengler, Gramsci, Weber, and Sorel. A Google N gram search suggests the term peaked in 1873; the work of Poulantz as and Baehr, worth exploring, are outliers.

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